GRADE 10 / History / English

Explain the French Revolution

01 Understand

Learning goals: Distinguish a long-term cause from a trigger • Build a causal explanation • Evaluate the limits of a source

Before 1789, French society was divided into estates with unequal privileges. Social inequality and debates about political authority contributed to criticism of the old order.

State debt and a fiscal crisis increased pressure for reform. Harvest failures and high bread prices intensified popular hardship.

A revolution has interacting causes. A single event can trigger action without explaining the longer processes that made it possible.

Selected sequence — not a complete chronology

Date	Event	Historical use
Before 1789	fiscal and social tensions	longer-term context
May 1789	Estates-General meets	political confrontation
14 July 1789	Bastille stormed	popular action
August 1789	Declaration of Rights	new political principles

02 Follow the reasoning

Explain how financial crisis and inequality could combine to weaken the monarchy.

1. Debt and difficulties raising revenue made the government seek fiscal and political solutions.

2. Unequal privileges made reform contentious and encouraged demands for fairer representation and taxation.

3. Connect these pressures: a financial problem opened a political confrontation in an already unequal society.

GRADE 10 / History

Practise with purpose

03 Try before checking

Use paper or your notebook. Show your reasoning. For written responses, use evidence and explain your choices. Suggested time: 15–20 minutes.

1. Name one long-term social cause.

2. Why is the storming of the Bastille insufficient as the only explanation for revolution?

3. What should you check before using a political cartoon as evidence?

04 Check and correct

1. The unequal privileges and burdens of the estate system.

2. It describes an event but does not explain the prior social, fiscal and political conditions.

3. Creator, date, intended audience, purpose, symbols and what the cartoon can and cannot show.

Common mistake to avoid

A source can be useful even when partisan; identify what its perspective reveals and corroborate factual claims.

Reflect and revisit

Identify one correction in your own words. Attempt a similar question tomorrow without looking at the guide. If you are still unsure, take your attempt to a teacher or tutor.

Coverage and sources

CAPS topic focus: The French Revolution: causes and historical skills

DBE CAPS, Grades 10–12: History. Section 3 content and skills. This is a focused supplement, not a complete syllabus or prescribed literature replacement.

Open the official DBE curriculum reference

Content and visuals: original SmartBridge FET. AI-assisted authoring; subject-teacher and language-specialist review pending. Report an issue with the pack ID hist-10.